

Communique

The Agricultural Workforce Working Group (the Working Group) met for the fifth time on 5 April 2023.

Members endorsed joint labour hire licensing principles for consideration by the Government in designing a national scheme, implementation of which would fulfil one of the recommendations of the Migrant Workers' Taskforce. This is a significant step forward, being the first time that agricultural and processing employer groups and unions have reached agreement on the principles that should underpin the use of labour hire in the sector. These principles include that a national labour hire licensing scheme should be inclusive of all industries, appropriately resourced, effectively enforced and simple for businesses operating across jurisdictions.

Members also agreed to a coordinated plan to advocate for enhanced training options and opportunities for current and prospective workers in agriculture consistent with its previous endorsement of flexible industry-led training models such as AgSkilled 2.0 and an agricultural trade apprenticeship.

Members discussed opportunities to promote wider participation in the agriculture and meat processing sectors among women, First Nations Australians, people with disability, veterans and older Australians, including receiving insights as part of a panel discussion from those with relevant expertise and lived experience. Members agreed to undertake further work in collaboration with those communities to prioritise where and how efforts to promote inclusion in the agriculture and processing workforces can best be targeted.

Members had an initial discussion on the future of work in agriculture and processing sectors and its implications for employers and workers in the sectors. Issues canvassed included maximising the opportunities offered by innovation, digital technologies and sustainable farming. This will be followed up by a more detailed discussion in coming months.

Members also noted the update on action items being progressed through sub-groups focused on skills, migration, worker protection and attracting Australians.

The Working Group will next meet in May 2023.

Attendees

- Senator the Hon. Murray Watt, Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry
- Tony Mahar, CEO, National Farmers' Federation
- Ann Gardiner, National Council member, Australian Dairy Farmers
- Shane Roulstone, National Organising Director, Australian Workers' Union
- Patrick Hutchinson, CEO, Australian Meat Industry Council
- Jannette Armstrong, Executive Director - Farms, United Workers Union
- Matt Journeaux, Federal Secretary, Australasian Meat Industry Employees Union
- Richard Shannon, Executive Officer, NFF Horticulture Council
- Andrew Metcalfe AO, Secretary, Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry

- James Flintoft, Facilitator
- John Azarias, Special Advisor to the Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry on Agricultural Workforce Issues

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/about/news/stay-informed/communiques/ag-workforce-working-group-april-2023>